

Lou Robinson

Engineering Manager | Platform Engineering, Developer Experience & Engineering Effectiveness

Repeated track record scaling engineering organisations through high-growth funding stages: Dexory (Series A to C), Sylvera (Seed to Series B), InfoSum (Series B)

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PROFILE

Engineering leader specialising in platform engineering, developer experience, and engineering systems that improve organisational throughput, reliability, and delivery performance. Experienced leading platform and DevEx functions, shaping technical strategy, and enabling multiple engineering teams through scalable systems, automation, and engineering governance frameworks.

Actively building with AI: three production and in-development projects built entirely solo using Claude Code, Anthropic APIs, LLMs, and RAG architectures. Uses AI-assisted development as a daily practice and has led teams through AI workflow adoption, establishing standards for AI-generated code review and responsible deployment at production scale.

KEY ACHIEVEMENTS

- Led platform and DevEx strategy supporting multiple engineering teams across product and infrastructure domains, reporting directly to CTOs at Dexory, Sylvera, and Filament AI
- Improved perception system performance from approximately 30% to 80% accuracy through cross-functional engineering alignment and data-driven execution strategy, taking Block Stack and Pick Count from R&D; through to market launch
- Defined engineering effectiveness framework including metrics, reporting, and delivery visibility systems, improving forecasting accuracy and stakeholder confidence
- Reduced environment provisioning time from days to minutes through engineering-led automation initiatives
- Delivered over £12,000 in cost savings through structured vendor evaluation and engineering tooling optimisation
- Led ISO27001 readiness and engineering alignment across teams, embedding security and compliance into engineering systems and workflows
- Defined cloud infrastructure strategy including transition toward scalable, Kubernetes-based architecture at Sylvera, retiring a high-risk on-premise supercomputer
- Scaled engineering teams through high-growth funding stages across three organisations, with 15 direct reports at Dexory across perception and platform teams
- Built engineering leadership pipeline: two senior engineers promoted to staff engineer with their own direct reports
- Led AI-assisted engineering workflow adoption across teams, establishing standards for AI-generated code review, quality gates, and responsible deployment

PERSONAL PROJECTS

Building with AI as a daily practice, using Claude Code as the primary development tool across all projects:

Gatepost | TypeScript, Python, Anthropic API, Voyage AI, pgvector, Cloudflare | gatepost.org

B2B RAG-based compliance research tool for UK food and agricultural businesses. Designed and built end to end: vector embedding pipeline via Voyage AI, pgvector cosine similarity search, LLM generation with citation-enforcing prompts, audit logging, and parallel compliance checklist generation per business profile. Live with a founding customer.

Trophe | React, Supabase, TypeScript | trophe.uk

Consumer meal planning app with UK supermarket price comparison and recipe management. Built entirely solo, live with affiliate monetisation.

Epos | TypeScript, Anthropic API, Web Speech API, Cloudflare | epos.lourobinson.com

Voice conversation app for language learning, built to replace Duolingo for Greek. Simulates real conversations with native speaker personas using LLMs and browser-native voice-to-text. In development, with plans to integrate voice synthesis API for authentic accent simulation.

CORE SKILLS

AI-Native Engineering

- Daily use of Claude Code for production application development
- LLM integration, RAG architecture, and vector search (hands-on)
- AI workflow adoption leadership across engineering teams
- AI code review standards, quality gates, and responsible deployment practices
- Multi-model AI workflows: generative and review/testing separation

Engineering Leadership & Strategy

- Platform engineering strategy and DevEx leadership
- Developer experience as a product discipline
- Engineering systems and productivity frameworks
- Org scaling through funding-stage growth

Delivery & Operations

- Engineering governance and risk management
- Incident management and four-nines SLO ownership
- Engineering metrics, DORA, and delivery health reporting
- Delivery optimisation in lean, fast-moving teams

Technical Direction

- AWS, GCP architecture
- Kubernetes, Terraform, CI/CD systems
- Distributed systems and fleet management (Balena)
- TypeScript, Python, Node.js (production, solo builds)

EXPERIENCE

Engineering Manager | Dexory (Autonomous Robotics)

Sept 2024 – Present

Led engineering organisation of 15 direct reports across perception and platform teams, reporting directly to the CTO through a Series A to C funding journey.

- Led perception and platform squads of 15 direct reports, owning delivery, technical direction, and engineering culture across both teams
- Scaled perception team from 3 to 10 plus engineers while managing a platform team of 5, enabling parallel delivery across technical streams
- Took Block Stack and Pick Count from R&D; through to market launch, directing engineering execution and cross-team coordination throughout
- Led a structured improvement programme lifting perception accuracy from approximately 30% to 80% through coordinated cross-team execution and data-driven iteration

- Led platform team owning a distributed service running across a global fleet of remote autonomous robots managed through Balena, including Fleet Manager and Robot Manager products
- Sponsored and led adoption of AI-assisted engineering workflows across teams, establishing standards for AI-generated code review and responsible deployment
- Introduced engineering effectiveness metrics, sprint health reporting, and delivery visibility systems for CTO and executive stakeholders
- Built engineering leadership pipeline: two senior engineers promoted to staff engineer, each now leading their own reports

Head of Platform (DevOps, Developer Experience & QA) | Sylvera

Oct 2021 – Dec 2023

Led platform engineering function of 6 engineers across DevOps, DevEx, and QA disciplines, reporting directly to the CTO with budget ownership through a Seed to Series B funding journey.

- Defined platform engineering strategy improving developer experience and reducing operational friction across multiple product engineering teams
- Directed cloud infrastructure strategy, leading migration from on-premise supercomputer to Kubernetes-based, cloud-native architecture, eliminating a significant DR risk and enabling demand-based scaling
- Maintained four-nines SLO across platform services, owning incident management, blameless post-incident reviews, and RCA follow-through
- Led ISO27001 audit-readiness as a cross-functional programme, aligning engineering, security, and compliance stakeholders to a fixed deadline
- Introduced engineering metrics and delivery visibility systems, improving decision-making and stakeholder confidence
- Delivered over £12,000 in cost savings through structured vendor evaluation and tooling optimisation

Lead QA & DevOps Engineer | Ground Control

Mar 2024 – Sept 2024

- Led engineering-led transformation of environment provisioning, reducing setup time from days to minutes
- Improved operational consistency and delivery predictability across engineering environments and release cycles

Senior QA Engineer | InfoSum

2020 – 2021

Owned the full release cycle and testing strategy for a Series B ad-tech data clean room platform, handling anonymised sensitive data at scale under strict privacy and compliance constraints.

- Introduced structured QA and release governance that improved release confidence and reduced production incidents
- Contributed to streaming service and bloom filter design review, identifying API contract issues before production
- Worked in Golang on automation and testing infrastructure

Head of QA | Filament AI

2018 – 2020

Reported directly to the CTO, building and leading a QA function in an early-stage AI business.

- Built automation framework in Python, later migrated to Node.js to align with the engineering team's native stack
- Established quality engineering standards and release governance across product teams

QA Engineer | WiggleCRC, Iglu.com, Switch Concepts

Oct 2016 – 2018

Progressed through QA engineering roles across e-commerce, building and owning test automation frameworks in multiple languages and stacks.

- Built a Ruby test automation framework at WiggleCRC and ported it to C# after developers declined to work in Ruby — an early lesson in building tooling for adoption rather than technical preference
- Built a Java-based test automation framework at Iglu.com and migrated it to C# to align with the team's native development language
- Introduced PHP-based test automation at Switch Concepts before the company ceased trading
- Developed deep polyglot testing foundations across Ruby, C#, Java, and PHP, later extended through Python, Node.js, and Golang in subsequent roles
- Speaker at Zapple Tech (2022): 'Delusions of Automated Testing' — argued against codeless automation tools in favour of building test infrastructure alongside developers in their own language and stack

Insurance Professional | Ageas Insurance

2008 – Oct 2016

Over eight years across motor, household, and personal injury insurance, developing deep domain knowledge in a highly regulated, customer-facing environment.

- Began driving adoption of automated testing practices toward the end of tenure, before moving into software engineering full time
- Domain experience in regulated financial services directly informs approach to compliance, security, and operational rigour in engineering leadership

SPEAKING & WRITING

- Speaker, Zapple Tech (2022): 'Delusions of Automated Testing' — argued against codeless automation tools in favour of building test infrastructure alongside developers in their own language and stack. Delivered the talk immediately before a speaker selling codeless tooling.
- Author, 'The Ramblings of Lou Robinson, Bugfinder General' LinkedIn series (2020) — four articles on testing philosophy covering manual vs automated testing, automation architecture, and the limitations of codeless tools.

EDUCATION

- ISTQB Foundation
- BTEC Software Development